well. It is also worth noting that Patel and Mookerjee directly shaped the map of India as we know it today. Obviously, we have to appreciate the compulsions of that period to also grasp the factors driving decisions. But, somewhere in all that, there are learnings from the voices of dissent as we try to find new solutions to old problems. Whether it is the standing of the leaders concerned, the intensity of their differences or the importance of the issues, there are good reasons for us to look back at their urgings with fresh eyes.

If there is a symbol of loyalty and sacrifice in India's folklore, it is the elderly eagle-king Jatayu. He was very old and virtually blind when Sita was abducted by Ravana. Yet, as the demon-king crossed his path, Jatayu gave his all to prevent evil from happening. He attacked Ravana with his talons, broke his bow with his beak and brought down his chariot. But in the combat, he was bested by the abductor, who chopped off his wings and eventually left him to bleed and die. But before he did, Rama and Lakshmana found him and learnt who was responsible for the kidnapping of Sita. On his demise, the last rites were performed by Rama, who was truly moved by the sacrifice of Jatayu.

Thereafter, it was his elder brother Sampati who made the difference. The monkey contingent under Prince Angada was beginning to despair about finding Sita. As they spoke about Jatayu's fate, Sampati who overheard them came to their assistance. He used his extraordinary eyesight to locate Sita, although she was imprisoned far away in Ravana's garden in Lanka. It was this 'over-the-horizon' visibility that then allowed Lord Rama and the monkeys to now make their plans.

In India's case, too, those with experience and wisdom had insights to offer. Some of our leaders of that era contributed to national security by challenging decisions, even at great personal cost. Their loyalty was no less than that of Jatayu. And their insights, as we now appreciate all the more, as valuable as that of Sampati. We owe it to them and to ourselves to revisit their counsel.

PATEL AND NEW INDIA

In recent years, Patel has featured more prominently in our national debates and discussions on security. Part of the reason is the change in our political circumstances that allows him to be brought back from the shadows. But equally, it is a reflection of our times when hard challenges and multiple uncertainties have highlighted the importance of leadership. More than any other figure of contemporary India, Patel symbolizes strategic clarity and